

# 40 habits that (quietly) transformed my life (in 40 minutes)

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## Executive Summary

Brandon Carter distills 40 actionable habits — grouped into morning, training, diet, work, and nighttime routines — that he credits for building multiple multi-figure businesses, an eight-figure business, and an elite physique well into his mid-40s.

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## Morning Habits (Habits 1–6) 0:45

- **Habit 1 — Turn off your phone first thing in the morning**
  - Stay off your phone for the first hour of the day minimum
  - Opening your phone immediately exposes you to everyone else's agenda and demands
  - Brandon keeps his phone off even longer to protect focus on the tasks that "move the needle"
  - "That first hour needs to be about you"
- **Habit 2 — Water first thing in the morning**
  - Drink ~40 oz of water immediately upon waking
  - Brandon's first 16 oz is actually a pre-workout he preps the night before so he can jump into work instantly
  - Most people feel tired and low-energy simply because they are chronically dehydrated
  - Brandon personally drinks **2 gallons of water per day**
  - Minimum recommendation: at least **1 gallon per day**
  - Benefits: more energy, better skin, less fatigue
- **Habit 3 — Fast first thing in the morning**
  - Working within **5 minutes of getting out of bed** on an empty stomach
  - Describes fasted mornings as a "cheat code" — the empty-stomach pre-workout provides the most energy of the day
  - First meal is around **10:30 or 11:00 AM** after training is done
  - Time lost scrolling Instagram in the morning is time competitors use productively
- **Habit 4 — Write down your goals every day**
  - Specifically write **90-day goals** every single morning
  - The philosophy: accomplish a year's worth of work every 90 days — requires aggression and laser focus
  - Writing them daily puts the goal top of mind; "there's something special about writing down your goals every day"
- **Habit 5 — Let AI help you build your day**
  - AI agents know the overall game plan and map out his calendar daily across personal life, business, fitness, and other goals
  - "I leave no white space. White space is where the devil lives."
  - How it works:
    - AI takes transcripts of every meeting with staff, team, and clients
    - Extracts action items from those transcripts
    - Estimates time needed for each task
    - Finds gaps in the calendar and fills them automatically

- The AI agent has a hard mandate: **never leave white space in the calendar**
- Calendar includes personal time (girlfriend, family), workouts, and business — not just work
- Brandon was manually doing this structured calendar approach before AI existed
- **Habit 6 — Start tracking everything, and do it the moment it happens**
  - Don't try to remember details at the end of the day — track in real time
  - What Brandon tracks:
    - Daily water intake
    - Every food item and every macronutrient
    - Hours spent developing new skills
  - Tracking allows you to see progress weekly and monthly and make data-driven decisions
  - "If you are not tracking, you are slacking."

## Training Habits (Habits 7–12) 4:11

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- **Habit 7 — Do full body workouts 4–5 days per week**
  - Brandon strongly rejects the "bro split" model
  - Scientific rationale: protein synthesis (muscle growth) only lasts ~**48 hours** after resistance training
    - A chest-day split means you're missing 5 days of potential chest muscle growth per week
  - How to structure a full body workout:
    - Pick **1–2 exercises per body part**
    - Do **3–4 sets** of each exercise
    - Rest only **60–90 seconds** between sets
    - Use a **smartwatch timer** (Brandon uses the Apple Watch Ultra) — raises arm and says "set 60-second timer" immediately after putting the weight down
    - Superset opposing muscle groups (e.g., chest exercise → back exercise → 60-second rest → repeat) to speed things up further
  - Full body workouts take Brandon **45–60 minutes**
  - Annual volume math:

| Approach              | Weekly Sets (Chest) | Annual Sets (Chest) |
|-----------------------|---------------------|---------------------|
| Bro split (chest day) | ~12 sets            | 624 sets            |
| Full body (4x/week)   | ~24 sets            | 1,248 sets          |

- **Habit 8 — Focus on compound exercises**
  - The 1–2 exercises per body part should be **compound movements**, not isolation
  - Compound movements build the most size — "bench press is what's going to get you big, dummy"
  - Isolation exercises (e.g., chest flies) are largely "junk sets" for the average person
  - Brandon does almost exclusively compound movements, especially for chest, back, and legs
  - Combined with full body frequency, the result: not only twice as many sets per year, but those sets are also roughly **twice as effective** as isolation-heavy splits
- **Habit 9 — Clean reps; do not ego lift**
  - Brandon attributes his near-zero major injuries over 27+ years of training to perfect form
  - True failure = when you can no longer lift the weight with **perfect form**, not when you can't lift it at all
    - If you're cheating form on bicep curls, your bicep has already failed — you're just recruiting other muscles and risking injury
  - Fix: instead of cheating reps, do a **drop set** (lower the weight immediately)
  - He is 44 years old with no major injuries after nearly 30 consecutive years of training
- **Habit 10 — Target 21 sets per muscle group per week**
  - This is Brandon's weekly volume goal
  - He notes this advice comes from coaching **thousands of people** over ~30 years, not just his own personal experience

- Was doing this volume naturally before starting testosterone replacement therapy (started TRT around age 40; started peptides even more recently)
- **Habit 11 — No more than 60 minutes in the gym**
  - Advanced cheat code: **split the 60-minute workout** into two 30-minute sessions or three 20-minute sessions throughout the day
  - Reasoning: no matter your fitness level, the first 20 minutes of a hard session will always be more intense than the last 20 minutes
    - "Why don't I just get three first halves?"
  - Brandon's setup: gym in his condo makes this practical — morning, afternoon, and evening micro-sessions
  - This applies regardless of diet or conditioning level — you simply cannot sprint for 60 minutes at the same intensity throughout
- **Habit 12 — Track your training volume like you track your money**
  - Count weekly sets per muscle group and verify you're hitting target numbers
  - Anything you're serious about must be tracked — training is no exception
  - "If you're not tracking, you're slacking."

## Diet & Eating Habits (Habits 13–19) 11:06

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- **Habit 13 — Stop drinking your calories**
  - Everything Brandon drinks has **zero calories**: water, pre-workout, diet soda
  - Drinking calories is wasteful — liquid calories don't satisfy hunger and add up fast
  - Not concerned about artificial sweeteners; dismisses those fears as unfounded
- **Habit 14 — Eat your protein first and track it**
  - Brandon consumes **250–300 g of protein per day**
  - Minimum recommendation: **1 gram of protein per pound of bodyweight**
  - Why aim higher than science studies suggest:
    - FDA allows food labels to be off by **up to 20%** in either direction
    - A protein bar labeled "10g protein" might actually have 8g or 12g
    - Solution: shoot for 20% more than you think you need to account for label inaccuracies
  - If food alone isn't cutting it: **whey protein** is a great tool — Brandon drinks it daily to hit protein targets while keeping calories controlled
- **Habit 15 — Use AI to help track your calories**
  - Brandon carries a **digital food scale** everywhere and weighs everything he eats
  - When a scale isn't available (e.g., at Miami Heat games where a bag isn't allowed in):
    - Take a photo of the food
    - Upload it to **Claude (AI)**
    - Ask it to estimate the weight and calculate macros
    - "It does a fairly good job. It's not perfect. It's not as good as a scale, but it's better than whatever the fuck you doing."
  - Tracks all calories in Claude as his primary logging tool
- **Habit 16 — Keep your calories under control**
  - Simple calorie formulas:

| Goal        | Formula                                |
|-------------|----------------------------------------|
| Lose weight | Bodyweight (lbs) × 10 = daily calories |
| Gain weight | Bodyweight (lbs) × 20 = daily calories |

- Also wear a fitness tracker to monitor calories burned:
  - Options mentioned: Apple Watch, Whoop, Garmin, **\*\*Oura Ring\*\*** (Brandon's preference — less conspicuous)
- Fat loss is math: to lose **\*\*2 lbs of fat per week\*\***, burn 1,000 more calories than you consume each day
- Weigh yourself daily to see if you're trending in the right direction, then calibrate
- **Habit 17 — Eat the same foods all the time**
  - People in the best shape tend to eat roughly the same things every day

- Brandon eats the same breakfast and lunch most days; variety comes when eating out or with friends
- Prefers **chicken thighs** over chicken breasts (too bland) — extra fat fits his ketogenic diet
- Brandon has been on the **ketogenic diet for 11 consecutive years** with no cheat days in almost 4 years
- **Habit 18 — Stop fearing fat**
  - There are essential amino acids (protein) and essential fatty acids (fat) — **no such thing as an essential carbohydrate**
  - To keep calories low, something must be cut — fat and protein are non-negotiable; carbs are the logical cut
  - Carbohydrates don't directly give you energy — **glucose** does; carbs just convert to glucose easily
  - Alternative glucose source: excess protein undergoes **gluconeogenesis** (converted to glucose), keeping muscles full even on keto
  - Brandon consulted **Dr. Dominic D'Agostino** on this topic
  - Key point: eating fat is fine; make sure you're getting enough fat
  - Caveat: keto is not required — many people are in great shape without it; the key is adequate fat intake
- **Habit 19 — Do a 72-hour fast occasionally**
  - Frequency: roughly **once a month**, or whenever feeling less lean than desired
  - Strategy: schedule fasts around times when maximum focus on work is needed
  - Brandon doesn't train during fasts — uses the time to lock in on work
  - Claims he can get **~two weeks' worth of work done in 72 hours** during a fast

## **Work Habits (Habits 20–33) 19:11**

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- **Habit 20 — Ship something every day**
  - Produce and publish something new every single day: YouTube videos, Reels, new ads, new ad creatives, new copy
  - "Nobody got rich in their notes app."
  - Mistake of aggression > mistake of timidity — volume wins over perfection
  - Brandon posts **8–10 Reels per day** created specifically for Instagram, TikTok, and Shorts (not just YouTube clips)
  - Ad creative example: ads that worked great for 6 months eventually stopped — businesses that go 6 months without new creatives are making a critical mistake
    - Brandon's standard: **new ads every week**, continuously trying to beat existing winners
  - When a video bombs, he doesn't notice because he's already working on the next five
  - Tracks the **trend line**, not individual video views — and only cares about it as it ties to gross revenue
- **Habit 21 — Batch similar work**
  - Minimize task-switching to stay in flow
  - Brandon's daily structure:
    - **Morning** — creative work
    - **Midday** — admin tasks
    - **Afternoon** — more creative work
  - AI agents and assistants are given a mandate: only schedule certain task types during certain time blocks
  - Zigzagging between creative, spreadsheet, filming, and meetings prevents ever reaching flow state
- **Habit 22 — Study what's already winning**
  - Research before creating — don't try to invent something from scratch
  - Great copywriters maintain a **"swipe file"**: a collection of the best copy they've encountered
    - Referenced: **David Ogilvy** as an example
    - The practice: make your own version inspired by what's working; put your own spin on it
  - Apply this to everything: business models, content formats, ad creative
  - "Nobody really invents shit. We all take what's working and put our own spin on it."
  - Analogy: no one had to invent algebra to use it — you learned what others built
- **Habit 23 — Run it back; keep doing what's working**
  - A shockingly common mistake: entrepreneurs find something that works, then inexplicably stop doing it
  - Brandon's theory: they stop because they aren't tracking, so they lose sight of what was actually working

- Not only keep doing it — **double down** on what works
- **Habit 24 — Check your numbers daily**
  - Numbers to review every morning:
    - Bank account balance
    - Bodyweight
    - Macros
    - Daily leads coming in
    - Cost of customer acquisition
    - Customer lifetime value
    - Cash on hand
  - Brandon has an AI agent deliver a full rundown of personal and business numbers every morning
- **Habit 25 — Automate one task per week with AI**
  - Don't try to automate everything at once — start with one task, get good at it, add more
  - Brandon's content pipeline: all social media content edited by AI; high output volume is a result
  - Starting point recommendation: **Muse** (free AI agent tool)
    - Connect it to your email
    - Instruct it: "Every day, go through my email, figure out what's going on, draft a response — don't send it, just draft it for me to review"
    - Once comfortable, ask the agent: "What else can you take off my plate?"
  - Other tools mentioned: **Grok/Grokbot**, **ChatGPT Pro (\$500/month)** with Codex, **Claude**
  - "This video was edited by AI."
- **Habit 26 — Write SOPs for everything you do repeatedly**
  - Source inspiration: **The E-Myth** (book) — first place Brandon learned this
  - Solo entrepreneurs must do everything: marketing, sales, customer service, product development
  - Scaling requires either hiring people or using AI — but neither works without a documented system
  - Process:
    - Write down every repeated task as a step-by-step standard operating procedure
    - Give that SOP to a new hire or to AI as their job manual
  - McDonald's analogy: any employee off the street can run a McDonald's because SOPs cover every task
  - Applies to life SOPs too, not just business
- **Habit 27 — Hire people to do what you hate**
  - Once making enough money, use SOPs to hire out tasks you hate or tasks that will buy back the most time
  - AI-first options (low cost):
    - ChatGPT Pro plan: **~\$500/month** — can automate heavily with Codex or ChatGPT operator agents
    - Grokbot automation
    - Individual AI agents: **\$100–\$200** range
  - Or hire a human — "sounds primitive now, but it works"
  - Key mentor lesson: "You're worried about the size of your slice, but your job is to make the pie so big that even a small slice is more than you're getting now."
- **Habit 28 — Watch your game tape**
  - Record and review everything you do, especially sales calls
  - What to look for on sales call recordings:
    - Micro-expressions showing emotional reactions
    - Moments where the salesperson lost control of the conversation
    - Stumbling, unclear pitching, missed objection handling
  - Brandon's onboarding process for new salespeople: **read the sales script out loud 100 times** before getting on a live call — know it so well you can think about other things while delivering it
  - Applies beyond sales: presentations, coaching sessions, content — watch your footage, get an outside evaluator

- **Habit 29 — Squeeze what you already have before your next launch**
  - Before launching something new, mine your existing email list for old leads and current clients who could be upsold
  - Brandon hasn't launched something truly new in a long time — his follow-up systems with AI keep revenue flowing from existing assets
  - AI doesn't do outreach autonomously — it flags leads that haven't been contacted in a while, then a human reaches out
  - Warning pattern: entrepreneurs who constantly pivot (forex → Bitcoin → dropshipping → next thing) signal they haven't mastered anything
- **Habit 30 — No shiny object syndrome**
  - Distinction: adopting new tools that optimize your existing business ≠ switching businesses
  - Brandon adopted AI tools to optimize his online fitness business — he didn't change industries
  - Counterpoint: you also can't ignore major shifts — don't be **Blockbuster** (referenced Netflix putting them out of business)
  - Brandon added trading to his repertoire ~6 years ago and made good money, but it's not his main thing — "keep the main thing the main thing"
  - "I turn down way more shit than I say yes to."
- **Habit 31 — Spend like you're bootstrapping, no matter where you are**
  - Story: a former student became Brandon's most successful student ever, making very large numbers
    - Brandon warned him to always keep money aside — recessions happen every ~10 years, algorithms change, ad platforms change, businesses get banned
    - The student appeared to agree, then bought an extremely expensive car shortly after
    - Business fell apart; student had to downgrade standard of living
  - Lesson: booming economies make everyone look like a genius; few businesses survive downturns
  - Brandon's rules:
    - Keep **maximum cash reserves** at all times
    - One-time splurges (e.g., his \$200,000 watch) are acceptable **only when paid for by investment returns**, not operating income
    - Assets pay for luxury items — "My money bought me this watch"
    - Recurring monthly/yearly expenses: **extremely reluctant** to increase these
  - "When, not if, something bad happens, I want to have a ton of cash I can throw at the problem and kill it."
- **Habit 32 — Never fake your numbers**
  - Some high-revenue coaching clients report "contracted revenue" as their income — payment plans promised vs. money actually received
    - Example: calling a \$500/month payment plan a "\$100,000 deal" when there's no guarantee of collection
  - "You can't fix what you fake."
  - The only number that matters: **how much money hit the bank account in the last 12 months**
- **Habit 33 — Do weekly, monthly, and quarterly reviews**
  - Weekly review: how many victories did you have this week? Was it a victorious week?
  - Monthly review: assess performance over the full month
  - Quarterly review: what worked, what didn't, what can improve
  - Framework: anyone can be on point for one day — the challenge is **7 consecutive successful days**
  - AI can assist in compiling these reviews from tracked data

## 🌙 Nighttime Routine Habits (Habits 34–40) 34:33

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- **Habit 34 — Nightly accountability check**
  - Review the calendar: did you accomplish everything scheduled?
  - If something wasn't done: move it, and analyze why it wasn't completed
  - Brandon's AI agents monitor his project management tools and flag incomplete tasks
    - Agents are trained to ask: "What prevented you from accomplishing this?" — then adjustments are made
  - Repeated daily, this process progressively improves goal achievement rate
- **Habit 35 — Treat every day like Game 7**
  - Every single day is treated with Super Bowl / NBA Finals Game 7 urgency

- At the end of each day, check the scoreboard — did you win today?
- Benefits:
  - Creates daily urgency to accomplish more
  - Eliminates waiting for some future milestone to feel good — you can "win the championship" every day
- Compounding logic:
  - Win today → victorious day
  - Stack 7 → victorious week
  - Stack 4 weeks → victorious month
  - Stack 12 months → victorious year
  - Stack years → exponential-looking rise that is actually just daily stacked wins
- "Once the plan is set, all my focus is for today. Today got to be a victory."
- **Habit 36 — (Reinforced) Never fake your numbers**
  - Covered as a standalone habit in the work section but emphasized again in the nightly context
  - Real-time tracking and nightly review only work if the numbers are honest
- **Habit 37 — Read 2 books per week and extract one implementable idea**
  - Brandon has read **2 books per week since age 19**
  - Took a speed-reading course in his early 20s; peak reading speed reached **600 words per minute**
  - Reads exclusively **non-fiction**: personal development and business books — no fiction
  - Reading mindset: not evaluating whether the book is good; actively hunting for **one gem to implement this week**
  - A single implementable idea can produce outsized results — especially in a fast-moving business
    - Analogy: a small steering adjustment at low speed = minor change; same adjustment at high speed = you're in a ditch (or on a new trajectory)
  - Has read far more books than visible in the video; twice as many in storage from his New York move, plus Kindle library
- **Habit 38 — (Reinforced) Weekly review**
  - Recapped: stack victorious days into a victorious week; review to confirm and learn
- **Habit 39 — Monthly and quarterly reviews**
  - Monthly: check results vs. goals
  - Quarterly: deeper analysis — what worked, what failed, what to improve going forward
- **Habit 40 — Always be willing to be a beginner**
  - Whenever learning something new, Brandon **immediately hires a coach** rather than figuring it out alone
  - Reasoning: if the new skill will make money, time spent learning slowly = money left on the table
    - The faster he learns, the faster he can monetize — so paying to accelerate learning is ROI-positive
  - Ego check: Brandon has hired coaches who earn **significantly less than him** because they have specialized knowledge he wants
    - "He knows this one thing and I want to learn this one thing."
  - Applies to any domain — never let ego prevent you from being a student

"If you are not tracking, you are slacking." — The single phrase Brandon returns to most throughout the entire video; tracking is the foundation that makes every other habit work.